Unchosen

A mirror with no bottom, and a man who kept looking for a door back to her.

Table of Contents

Prologue: The Comfort of a Wrong Ending **3**

Chapter 1: A House Built From Other People's Grief **4**

Act 1: The Illusionist *5*

Act 2: Ghost *5*

Act 3: Telepathy *6*

Act 4: The Mirror *7*

Act 5: The Man Who Hid *8*

Chapter 2: What Death Left Whole **9**

Chapter 3: The Last Honest Answer **12**

Act 1: The Meeting *12*

Act 2: What He Learned *13*

Act 3: The Years *13*

Act 4: The Confession *14*

Act 5: What Came After *15*

Act 6: Goodbye *15*

Act 7: The Life That Never Happened *16*

Act 8: The Search *17*

Chapter 4: A Hunger Older Than the Witch **19**

Act 1: What It Found *19*

Act 2: The Slow Theft *20*

Act 3: What Remained *20*

Act 4: The Last of Him *21*

Chapter 5: One Face, Many Hungers **22**

Act 1: The Last Face *22*

Act 2: The Coldest Thing *23*

Act 3: One Body *23*

Act 4: A Door With a Face *24*

Act 5: Multiplication *24*

Act 6: The Mirrors Without Faces *25*

Act 7: The Plan *25*

Act 8: The Beginning of the End *26*

Chapter 6: Whichever Glass You Believe **27**

Act 1: The Shape of the Curse *27*

Act 2: What the Glass Kept *28*

Prologue

The Comfort of a Wrong Ending

I. The Tale of the Lost Soul (a fragment)

There was once a story about a man who loved a girl he could never have.

People told it in different ways.

Some called it a story about obsession. Others called it grief, or loneliness, or the plain foolishness of holding on to something that was never his to hold.

Some said the creature in the tale was only a shape given to his refusal to let go, a monster grown from love that had nowhere left to go.

The story was beautiful, told that way.

It was also wrong.

No one who repeated it had ever asked the one question that mattered: whether the curse had been real, or whether he had simply believed in it long enough to make it true.

(continued at the end)

Chapter 1

A House Built From Other People's Grief

Centuries ago, before he collected anything at all, a boy wanted to be loved, and a witch told him he never would be.

He did not remember her face anymore. He remembered the shape of the field where she'd found him, and the particular cold of that night, and the two things she'd said before she left him standing in the wet grass. That he could not die unless someone loved him truly. That no one ever would.

He had carried those two sentences for so long that he could no longer tell where the witch's voice ended and his own began. Perhaps she had cursed every stranger who looked at him to feel disgust. Perhaps she had simply told a frightened, unloved boy that he was unlovable, and time had done the rest, the way water finds the same crack in a stone for a thousand years until the stone believes the crack was always meant to be there.

He only knew what he remembered: that every face that ever looked at him too long eventually turned away.

He had tried, once, to prove it wrong. He had helped strangers rebuild homes that floods had taken. He had given his coat to men who spat at him for it after. He had loved carefully, in small doses, waiting to see how long it would take before the warmth curdled into something else. It never took long. A friend borrowed money and vanished. A woman he'd nursed through fever called him monstrous the moment she was well enough to see him clearly in daylight. Someone he trusted with the location of everyone he had ever protected sold that list for a price he never learned.

That last one had a name. He did not let himself think it often. Maze.

Eventually he stopped testing the curse and started managing it instead.

He learned that grief left things behind, a letter, a photograph, a coat still smelling faintly of someone who no longer wore it, and that he could not bear to let those things be thrown away, because if the objects vanished then the moments they belonged to would vanish too, and he would have nothing left to prove any of it had ever been real. So he began to keep them. A drawer became a chest. A chest became a room. A room became a house full of other people's discarded lives, and somewhere in that accumulation, a name attached itself to him without his choosing it. The Collector.

He did not choose the name any more than he had chosen the curse. He simply understood, eventually, that people needed to call a thing something, and this was the thing they had decided to call him.

Act 1: The Illusionist

He had known for a long time that he could make pictures out of nothing. He had never known what those pictures were for. Then one night, surrounded by everything he had kept, he tried to give one of them a shape that could move.

It moved.

He gave it a voice. It spoke. He gave it a purpose, and it walked to the door and opened it and closed it again, exactly as he'd asked, and stood there afterward waiting for the next instruction like a dog too well trained to need one.

He understood, watching it, that the objects were not merely proof. They were material. The more a thing had mattered to someone, the more convincing the shape he could build from it, a coat became a soldier's shoulders, a photograph became a face that could hold an expression, a wedding ring became a woman who would never again ask him for anything he couldn't give.

He called himself something else, for this. The Illusionist. Few people ever learned that the two names belonged to the same man. He preferred it that way. A collector gathers what is lost. An illusionist gives it somewhere to stand. Between the two of them, an empty house stopped being empty.

None of what he built could love him. He understood that going in. But none of it could leave, either, and for a man who had run out of ways to distinguish those two mercies from each other, that was enough for a while.

Act 2: Ghost

There had been an older name, from further back, that he wore again now the way a man returns to a coat he thought he'd outgrown.

He had built it long before any of this, in a life spent training a single unmarked recruit to survive a war fought entirely under false names, in a world where the wrong person learning your face could get everyone you loved killed. He had built codenames into that world like scaffolding, so that no name could ever again be used as a leash. He had trained that recruit past the point of mercy, and told himself it was necessary, and had never let himself sit too long with how much of it he had enjoyed, the one bond in his memory he could shape entirely by hand, that would never

once decide, on its own, to leave.

He did not think of that often either. It sat beneath the rest of him the way a foundation sits beneath a house nobody remembers being built.

So when he needed, once more, to disappear completely, to help people from inside a darkness no one could see his face in, he reached for the same discipline without noticing he was reaching for anything old at all. The same silence. The same mask, cut from different cloth but built on the same understanding: that a face was a liability, and a name was a door someone could walk through uninvited.

In Xenus they began telling their own small story about him. That if something hunted you in the dark, you should run toward the darkest part of the street, not away from it. That something waited there that would not let you be taken.

No one learned his face. He killed only the ones he judged deserved it, and only then did he let them see him, his real face, the one the curse had ruined, the last thing many of them ever saw before the dark took them. He did not enjoy their fear. He understood fear from the inside too well to enjoy causing it in anyone but the guilty.

It did not occur to him, not once, that the same hands doing this quiet mercy work in the dark were about to do something far less merciful in the light.

Act 3: Telepathy

Then one of the most powerful sentients in the world died, and the shape of everything around that absence went unstable, the way water goes unstable around a hole punched through ice.

The Collector had, by chance, kept something that had belonged to the dead man. It was enough.

He built an illusion good enough to fool an entire company that its leader had never died at all. While that false face ran meetings and signed papers and reassured frightened people that nothing had changed, The Collector remained beneath it, unseen, doing the actual work of controlling everything the illusion touched.

A few people noticed the wrongness first. He removed them, one at a time, and kept something of each, and made new illusions from what he kept, so that the people who vanished never seemed to have vanished at all. Familiar faces kept returning to work. Familiar voices kept answering familiar questions. None of it was real. All of it was him.

He told himself, for a while, that this was simply the largest room he had ever built. A place where no one could leave, because none of them had ever truly been there to begin with. A world that could not reject him, because he had made sure nothing in it was capable of rejecting anything.

It was not the empty house anymore. It had people in it, real ones, underneath the illusions, still breathing, still afraid, still paying for a kindness he had once tried to offer the world and had long since stopped remembering how to offer honestly.

Act 4: The Mirror

There was one place he had always been careful with. The mirror dimension, and the things that lived inside it, not ordinary reflections, but sentients with a world of their own, patient in the particular way that only patient things can afford to be.

He had used them for years, the way a man uses any tool he has decided is beneath his conscience. When someone became a problem he could not otherwise solve, he brought them to a mirror in the dark of his own house, took something that belonged to them, and let the reflections do the rest. He kept the object. He made an illusion. To everyone else, the missing person had simply never left.

He did this for so long that he stopped counting the ones he'd given away.

The reflections did not stop counting.

For a long time they had no way out but the gateways he controlled. Then something changed, some threshold crossed inside their own strange dimension, some pressure built from all that he had fed them across all those years, and one night the wall of a room he thought was secure came apart, and there were not one or two of them standing in the wreckage, but many.

He ran. He set every alarm the building had. He sent every illusion he had ever built to hold the line, including the one still wearing a dead man's face, and watched them all get pulled through mirrors they could not break fast enough. He escaped while they fought a battle none of them could have understood they were fighting for him.

The reflections lost that skirmish, in the sense that their gateways were shattered to sand behind them. They did not lose the memory of who had made them what they'd become.

Act 5: The Man Who Hid

He disappeared again, the way he always eventually disappeared. No empire. No illusions walking around wearing borrowed faces. Just Ghost, and the dark, and the particular quiet of a man who has run out of new ways to be someone else.

He told himself it would be enough to wait them out. Things that lived outside of time, he reasoned, should eventually grow bored of things that lived inside it.

He was wrong about that too, though he would not learn how wrong for a long while yet, long enough to walk a hundred more roads, and to sit down beside a river one afternoon beside a girl who commanded water and a dog who did not trust him for exactly as long as it took to decide it didn't matter.

He did not know, sitting down beside that river, that something on the other side of every mirror he had ever broken was still patient. Still counting. Still his.

He only knew that for the first time in longer than he could measure, someone had looked at him and not looked away.

(Twoychi and The Collector and Twoychi follow, his years with Aya, lived inside this same hiding, before he understood what was still waiting for him on the other side of the glass.)

Chapter 2

What Death Left Whole

There were two hearts inside her, and neither of them had asked to share a body.

One had belonged to a girl named Aya. The other had belonged to a dog named Troy. Death had tried, once, to take them separately. Whatever waited on the other side of it had not understood that the two of them had never learned how to say goodbye.

Aya woke with water moving around her fingers without disturbing them. Troy woke smaller than she remembered, rolled onto his back, and waited for her hand as though nothing at all had happened. She laughed before she cried, or cried before she laughed, she could never afterward say which came first.

"You're still here," she said.

His tail struck the ground. That was answer enough for both of them.

They learned the rules of it slowly, the way anyone learns rules that were never written down for them. Water came to Aya's hands the way breath comes to a chest, she could pull it from a river, gather it from the air on a dry day, or close a wound with it before the person bleeding understood they'd been touched. Troy could not be killed. He could be struck, buried, thrown, and drowned, and none of it held. Whenever a threat came near her, he was already moving before either of them decided he should.

A dog became a wolf when there was one enemy. A wolf became six when there were more than one. A wolf became something too large for its name when there was no other choice, and the ground remembered it afterward whether or not Aya asked it to be gentler.

Most of the time, when nothing needed killing, he was simply the dog again. He slept beside fires. He slept on boats. He slept through arguments Aya had with strangers about payment she never intended to accept. Soldiers who had forgotten how to rest sat down next to him and, without meaning to, remembered how.

There was a night, once, in a camp far from anywhere with a name, when a soldier was carried in already past saving, the kind of wound men did not survive, the kind everyone in earshot had already stopped hoping about. Aya knelt beside him anyway. She did not do anything anyone could describe afterward. She simply held his hand and waited, the way a person waits at a door they already expect to open the wrong way.

He lived. No one could say how. Aya did not explain it, and no one who saw her face in that moment thought to ask her to.

If Aya died, his soul stayed wherever she'd fallen until she came back to it. No distance changed that. No world between them changed it either. People called it a curse on both of them, or a blessing, or proof that one of them was the reason the other survived. None of them had the shape of it right. They simply did not know, between the two of them, how to be the ones left behind.

They crossed kingdoms that had stopped remembering their own names. They gave water to strangers in places that had none. They were feared in some towns and welcomed in others, sometimes on the same road, a day apart. People remembered the wolf. People remembered the bear that flattened men twice its size without malice, the way a landslide has no malice. But the people who knew her best remembered the dog who wandered into the middle of a battlefield, looked at everyone involved, and lay back down beside her as though none of it concerned him.

"Lazy," she told him once, scratching behind an ear he offered without lifting his head.

He closed his eyes. For a while, the world agreed to wait.

There was one absence Aya carried that never got smaller no matter how far they walked. A name she almost never spoke. Someone missing long enough that missing him had simply become one more thing she did, the way she breathed, or slept lightly, or disliked wasting food.

Among the people who came and went through the years that followed, there was a man who stayed longer than most. The first time he looked at her directly, she looked back a half-second longer than the moment asked for, the way a person checks a face against a memory they can't place, and doesn't find it, and lets the moment pass without remarking on it. He noticed. He did not know what he'd noticed. Neither, really, did she.

He learned her habits the way a person learns the habits of someone they've decided to keep. He knew when she was lying about being tired. He knew that Troy preferred shade over sun and would not admit it. He knew how she took her tea, and which of her scars she would talk about and which she would not.

To him, every one of those small things became something worth keeping.

To Aya, they were simply what a person learns about a friend.

He loved her the other way, the way she never returned. When he finally told her so, she did not laugh, and she did not make it smaller than it was. She told him the truth instead, which cost her more than a lie would have and gave him less comfort than one might have too.

Her heart already belonged to someone who was not there.

He tried to stay close after that. She tried to make the staying easier on him. Neither of them managed it. Eventually she began to leave without waiting for him some mornings, not because she had stopped caring what happened to him, but because she had started to understand that caring loudly, after a confession like his, was its own kind of cruelty.

To her, in the end, he had been a very close friend. Nothing more. There were others like him in the years before and the years after, people she had loved as family and never as anything else. None of them had been the one she was still waiting for.

She never learned, afterward, how far his grief would carry him, or what he would eventually be willing to walk into in order to stop feeling it. To her he simply became another person she had once loved without knowing quite how much of him she was letting go.

Troy watched her scratch at a river's edge some evenings, watched the water gather around her ankles and go still, and never once asked when she planned to stop waiting.

He had followed her through death itself. He already knew the answer.

She never would.

Chapter 3

The Last Honest Answer

He had kept many things in his long life. Names. Faces. Habits. The particular sound a person's voice made just before they said something they'd been holding onto too long.

He had never kept anyone the way he kept Aya.

Act 1: The Meeting

He found her on a road that had been abandoned by nearly everyone who used to travel it, a river on one side, the bones of a settlement on the other, doors that no longer had anywhere they were meant to keep out.

She was sitting beneath a tree with her hands in the water. It moved around her fingers without touching them. A dog slept against the roots beside her.

He stopped. The dog opened one eye.

She looked up at him first, before the dog fully woke, one long moment where her eyes moved over his face like a hand checking a lock it already expected to find open, and didn't. Whatever she was looking for, she didn't find it. She never mentioned it. Neither did he, though something in him noted the look the way a man notes a draft from a window he can't locate.

"You can keep walking," she said, without looking up.

"I wasn't planning to stop."

The dog opened the other eye, considered him the way a judge considers evidence, and went back to sleep.

"I suppose he disagrees," he said.

"He's usually right."

Nothing more remarkable than that happened. No prophecy. No battle. Just a conversation beside a river, and a dog too tired to bother distrusting a stranger properly.

Their roads kept overlapping after that, in the accidental way roads do until neither traveler bothers pretending the overlap is accidental anymore.

Act 2: What He Learned

She was, he came to understand, simple in exactly the places he had expected to find complications. She helped people and never asked to be repaid. She fought when fighting solved something and walked away the instant it stopped solving anything. She preferred sitting near water. She slept lightly. When she was worried her hands went still instead of restless. When she was angry she grew quieter, not louder.

Sometimes, believing no one listened, she talked to the dog about nothing, the weather, a meal, a place she wanted to see someday. He listened anyway. Underneath the nothing, he began to hear the shape of someone she never named directly. An absence with its own gravity, pulling at the way she stared across rivers sometimes, at the parts of herself she kept carefully out of every conversation.

He did not ask. He told himself that simply being present, for once, might turn out to be enough.

He was wrong, though it would take him years to learn exactly how wrong.

Act 3: The Years

They crossed deserts where she gave away water until her own strength thinned. They walked into wars without belonging to either side of them. Sometimes he vanished for weeks at a time on business he never explained, and when he returned she would look up and say, "You're alive," and he would say, "Disappointed?" and she would say, "Not particularly," and the dog would sniff him once and go back to sleep, satisfied that nothing important had changed.

He began bringing her small things. A carved scrap of wood. A coin from a country that no longer existed. A flower pressed flat between pages. Nothing valuable, he told himself he only wanted to see what her hands would do with something unexpected in them.

There was a night, on one of those crossings, when a wound he should not have survived opened him from shoulder to ribs, and by the time he understood how badly, she was already kneeling over him, her hands already moving, faster than the distance between them should have allowed. He never asked her how she'd gotten there so quickly. She never offered to explain it. He decided, because it was easier than the alternative, that he had simply misjudged how far away she'd been standing.

What he was actually collecting, he understood only much later, was her. Not objects. Reactions. The smile she tried to suppress when something struck her as ridiculous. The particular way she turned a thing over three times before deciding where it belonged.

Somewhere in all of that collecting, a future built itself inside him without his permission. A house near water. The dog asleep by a door. Her repairing something at a table while he came home from wherever a man like him went. Years passing without either of them having to leave.

None of it had happened. All of it felt, to him, like something he already owned.

He should have known better than anyone alive how dangerous that particular kind of ownership was.

Act 4: The Confession

It happened beside a dying fire, the dog asleep between them, Aya mending a tear in her sleeve with the kind of attention she gave to things that mattered less than she pretended.

"I love you," he said.

Her hands stopped. She did not look surprised. That, more than anything else that night, was the part that stayed with him.

"I know," she said.

"You knew?"

"For a while."

"And said nothing."

"What was there to say?"

He had no answer for that. She set the cloth down in her lap.

"I care about you. You're one of my closest friends."

The word landed harder than anything with an edge could have.

"My heart already belongs to someone else," she said, when he asked her to say more.

"Even after everything?"

"Yes."

"Even if he never comes back?"

"Yes."

"And if he did?"

"I'd still choose him."

He hated the man he had never met, for the length of one breath. Then he hated himself for hating someone who had done nothing but exist somewhere out of reach. She had not lied to him. She had not led him anywhere on purpose. She had simply told him, finally, the truth that had been sitting between them the entire time he chose not to see it.

"I understand," he told her.

She looked at him and knew that he did not. Not really. There was nothing else worth saying, so neither of them said it.

Act 5: What Came After

Nothing changed the next morning, which was somehow the cruelest part of all of it. The dog still wanted feeding. She still needed water. The road still went on ahead of them exactly as it had the day before.

But everything ordinary now carried a second meaning underneath it. Her smile made him wonder what it cost her. Her closeness made him wonder whether it was kindness or guilt. Every mention of the man she was still waiting for collapsed a little more of the future he'd built without her knowledge.

She began sitting farther away. Their conversations shortened. She left some mornings without telling him where. He never confronted her about any of it, because he understood exactly why she was doing it, and understanding made it worse rather than easier.

Neither of them had done anything wrong. There was simply no way through that situation where both of them kept everything they wanted to keep.

Act 6: Goodbye

It came on a gray morning, the road ahead of them empty, the dog standing between the two of them like a boundary neither had asked him to hold.

"You should go," she said.

"I don't want to."

"I know."

"I can stay. I can be your friend."

"You'll always want more than that."

He had no answer.

"I don't want to lose you," she said.

"Then don't."

"That isn't enough."

He knew she was right. He hated her for it for exactly as long as it took to start hating himself instead.

She almost said something else, then. He saw it arrive behind her eyes and saw her decide, deliberately, not to let it out, the way a person catches a door before it swings wide enough to show what's behind it. Whatever it cost her to hold that back, it cost her more than the goodbye itself seemed to.

"When we meet again," she told him, "if your feelings are gone, we can be friends again."

He almost laughed. Not because any of it was funny. Because they both already knew his feelings were not going anywhere, that a man who had outlived kingdoms and buried more names than either of them could count had never once, in all that time, learned how to let go of anything smaller than a name.

"I understand," he said.

She nodded. "Goodbye."

The dog looked back at him once before following her. Then the road took them, and he did not follow, not because he had accepted any of it, but because he understood that chasing her would only turn what he felt into something uglier than grief.

That was the last time he saw her.

Act 7: The Life That Never Happened

He had survived death before. He had survived abandonment, more than once. This was a different kind of losing, he was mourning a house that had never been built, children who had never been born, a whole shape of a life that existed nowhere except behind his own eyes, which meant there was nothing anywhere to bury.

Every morning he woke into the version of the world where none of it had happened. That, more than her rejection itself, was what wore him down to nothing. Not the loss of Aya. The loss of the future he had already, privately, moved into.

He began seeing her everywhere and never finding her anywhere. A stranger's turned head. A laugh that moved a hand the way hers moved. Every one of them collapsed back into someone else the moment they looked at him directly, and every collapse cost him a little more than the last.

He went back to what he knew. He collected. Objects, letters, artifacts, broken things, none of it helped for longer than a day, sometimes an hour, before another face from a distance brought her back and he had to start again.

He understood, finally, the one thing in his long existence he had never managed to collect. Her heart. He could keep her memory forever. He could never make it choose him.

Act 8: The Search

Grief became a search, the way grief in a man with too much time on his hands often does. He looked first for stories, then for artifacts, then for places where the rules of reality bent enough to matter. He told himself he was looking for a way back to her. That was only partly true. What he actually wanted was a version of the world where the parting had never needed to happen at all, a road that continued differently, a confession that received a different answer, a house that existed somewhere with a dog sleeping by its door.

He remembered, then, a door he had used many times before for reasons that had nothing to do with love. A dimension where nothing obeyed the same rules the overworld did. He had gone there often, once, to be rid of people he had decided did not deserve to remain in his world. He had never once gone there for himself.

He went back now, not running from anything this time, but toward something, toward the smallest, most impossible hope he had left, that somewhere past the glass there might be a version of his own story that hadn't gone this way.

He did not know, walking toward it, that the thing waiting on the other side of every mirror he had ever broken had never once stopped counting the debt he owed it.

He carried one memory in with him that he had never placed in any drawer, any chest, any vault. A fire. Her hands mending a tear. The dog breathing evenly between them. The version of her that existed just before he ruined the silence between them by telling her the truth.

He carried it past the threshold.

Something on the other side had been waiting a very long time for exactly this, a man walking in of his own will, carrying the one thing about himself he had never been willing to let go of.

It began, very quietly, to learn him.

Chapter 4

A Hunger Older Than the Witch

There is no good word for what waited behind the mirrors. Calling it a creature suggests it once had a childhood, a first shape, a single beginning it could point back to. Calling it a prisoner suggests the door had been shut on it by someone else. Both were partly true. Neither was the whole of it.

What is certain is this: long before it had ever taken a face, or a name, or learned the particular cruelty of choosing which parts of a stolen life to keep, it had a hunger it could not explain to itself. Not hunger for food, or for warmth, or for anything with a simple word attached. A hunger shaped like absence, like a hand reaching for a second hand that used to fit against it and finding, every time, only air.

It did not know why. It had stopped asking a long time before he arrived.

Act 1: What It Found

He walked in already carrying the thing it needed most: a memory he refused to let go of, wrapped so tightly around his sense of himself that the two had become the same object. A fire. A woman's hands. A dog breathing evenly in the dark between them.

It had taken others before him this way, pulled them through broken glass, studied what they carried, kept what was useful, discarded what wasn't. Most people, once inside, tried immediately to leave. He did not. He stood in the reflected dark and looked for a door that led backward, to a version of his own story where a woman had once said yes instead of the truth, and in looking for that door instead of an exit, he showed the thing studying him exactly where he was weakest.

It began there. Small things first. It borrowed the sound of his voice before it borrowed anything else, testing the shape of it the way a hand tests a glove before deciding to wear it.

He did not notice, not at first, that something nearby had started answering him in his own tone half a beat before he spoke.

Act 2: The Slow Theft

Time did not move the same way behind the glass. He could not have said, afterward, whether it took him days or decades to stop being entirely himself. He remembered fighting it, early, remembered standing very still and reciting, deliberately, everything he still knew to be true. His name, before Ghost. The names of people he had trained. The particular ache of a fire he had once sat beside, uninvited into someone else's heart.

It let him recite all of it. It listened the way a thief listens to a man describe exactly where he keeps his valuables.

Then, patiently, it began replacing pieces of him with copies so faithful that he mistook them for the originals. A memory of Aya's laugh, borrowed and returned slightly wrong, so gently wrong that he never noticed the seam. A memory of Maze's betrayal, sharpened at the edges until it fit more easily into the shape of every other betrayal he'd ever survived, until all of them started to feel like the same wound wearing different clothes. Somewhere in that blurring, his history stopped being a sequence of things that had happened to him and became, instead, raw material, indistinguishable from every other stolen history already layered inside the thing that was doing the stealing.

He understood, near the end of whatever could still be called his own understanding, that this was not punishment. Punishment would have required it to know, or care, what he had done to deserve this. It did not hate him. It did not love him either. It simply needed what he had, the way water needs a lower place to run toward, without malice, without a reason beyond the shape of the ground.

Act 3: What Remained

Near the very last of it, in the narrow space where he was still, technically, a single mind rather than a layer inside a larger one, something surfaced in him that had nothing to do with Aya, nothing to do with Ghost, nothing to do with any name he had ever answered to.

An image, uninvited: something sealed shut, a lock he had never chosen and could not have described the shape of. A sense, not a memory, nothing so orderly as a memory, of having once been more than one thing, in more places than one, and of all of those places closing into a single point at exactly the same instant, the way a held breath finally has to leave the body all at once.

He did not know where the image came from. He had never seen a lock like that in his life. It did not belong to him, and yet it did not feel foreign either, it felt older than anything that did belong to him, older than the witch, older than the field she had found him standing in.

He reached for a name to put to it, some instinct in him certain that naming a thing was the only way to hold onto it, and found nothing there. Not Aya. Not Ghost. Not the boy from the field before either name had ever touched him. Something else entirely, something that felt, absurdly, like it should have had a sibling, like there should have been a second version of this same ache standing somewhere just out of reach, having survived what he apparently had not.

The thought slipped away before he could close his hand around it. He never got it back.

Act 4: The Last of Him

By the time the process finished, there was very little left that could be called only his. His face remained, because it had been the freshest thing taken, and the freshest things always sat closest to the surface. His voice remained, in fragments, folded somewhere beneath thousands of other voices that had once belonged to thousands of other people who had also, at some point, stood exactly where he was standing and refused to let go of exactly one thing.

Only one memory stayed whole, untouched, uncopied, sitting apart from everything else the way a single stone sits apart from a riverbed that has worn every other stone smooth. A fire. A woman mending a tear in her sleeve. A dog breathing evenly in the space between them.

It did not know, by the end, whose memory that was. It only knew that it could not stop returning to it, the way a tongue returns to a broken tooth, not out of love, if it had ever understood what love was, but because that single unworn memory was the last edge left in a place that had otherwise gone entirely smooth.

Somewhere far behind that memory, sealed and locked and utterly forgotten by the thing that now carried his face, was a name.

Aya.

It did not remember loving her.

It only knew that it did.

(The Reflection: New Body follows, what it became, once it stopped being only one, and what it finally chose to wear into the world.)

Chapter 5

One Face, Many Hungers

It had spent the better part of its existence behind glass. That limitation ended the day the last gateway shattered wide enough to let it through whole.

It walked beneath open sky for the first time. It crossed roads it had only ever seen reversed. It stood in crowds and watched people move past it, none of them understanding that something impossible had just joined the line beside them. Oceans it had known only as flat reflected surfaces turned out to have weight, and sound, and a horizon that did not end where a frame did.

It did not need to travel. It traveled anyway, the way a thing does something for the first time simply because it finally can.

Act 1: The Last Face

Before its gateways broke, it had taken one final person through the glass. He had not been the first. He had not been the most important. He had simply been the last, and because he was last, his shape had not yet been buried under everyone who came before him.

It remembered his face with unusual clarity. His voice. The particular way he walked, like a man perpetually deciding whether to stay or leave a room. It remembered, more than any of that, the way he had looked at a woman named Aya, a look it recognized without understanding, the way a blind man might recognize warmth without ever having seen where light came from.

She had been the center of him. To her, he had only ever been a very close friend. She had told him so, gently, honestly, and it had cost her something to say it and cost him everything to hear it. That goodbye was the last whole memory he carried before the glass took the rest.

The Reflection inherited all of it. The love. The gentle refusal. The particular ache of being kept, but never chosen.

For a while his identity remained separate from the others layered inside it. Then, slowly, the way a name worn too often in a crowd starts to lose its edges, it began to blur into everyone else it had ever taken. His face stayed. His name did not survive the blurring.

But something behind that face refused to dissolve all the way.

Aya.

So when the moment came to choose a single body to wear into the world, it reached, without knowing exactly why, for his.

Act 2: The Coldest Thing

Deep beneath that memory, beneath Aya, beneath the goodbye, beneath everything soft enough to still hurt, there was an older layer the merging had not yet worn smooth. A layer from further back than the mirror, further back than the woman by the river, further back than anything the Reflection understood as belonging to grief.

A boy with no name yet, trained by a boy who had once had a name taken from him. A recruit built up out of nothing, shaped one deliberate lesson at a time, until he could survive a war designed to consume him. Somewhere in that shaping, the man doing it had discovered something he never told anyone, not even himself, in so many words: that a person you build with your own hands cannot decide to leave the way a person who chooses you can.

He had told himself it was necessary. He had told himself it was mercy, disguised as discipline. Both of those had been true. Neither of them was the whole of it.

What was left, underneath both explanations, in the one memory the merging had not yet touched, was simpler and colder than either. He had enjoyed it. Not the cruelty of it, he had never taken pleasure in anyone's pain, not truly, not even the men he had killed with his own ruined face as the last thing they saw. What he had enjoyed was the certainty. A bond he did not have to hope would hold. A closeness that did not depend on being chosen, because he had built the choosing into it from the very first lesson.

That certainty had been the only kind of love he had ever fully trusted.

The Reflection did not judge him for it. It did not know how to judge anything. It only kept the memory, filed beside the woman he had loved honestly and lost anyway, the two of them sitting together in whatever passed for its mind, proof, if anything inside it still understood the word, that the same man capable of the second could also, quietly, without ever admitting it to himself, have been guilty of the first.

Act 3: One Body

There had been too many of them for too long. Thousands of instances, accumulated across broken mirrors and stolen lives, each one capable of standing on its own, each one carrying its own splinter of memory. They could have stayed separate.

Instead they folded into one another. One entered another. Voices merged into a single voice. Memories stopped belonging to any one of them and became, instead, layers inside a single consciousness too large for any single mind to have held from the start.

There was no visible struggle in it. No sound from the outside. Simply one body, standing where many had stood a moment before, his face, his hands, his eyes, assembled now out of every existence it had ever taken rather than out of the one man it had first belonged to.

It was not a singular identity. That had already been lost, thoroughly enough that it no longer noticed the loss. It was a singular shape, and inside that shape, thousands of minds went on existing the way rooms go on existing inside a house long after the family that built it has stopped answering to any of their old names.

Act 4: A Door With a Face

The greater change was not how it looked. It was what it had become underneath the looking.

It no longer needed a mirror to cross between worlds. It had become the crossing. Its skin held the memory of glass. Its eyes, looked into too long, showed something moving behind them that was not a room and was not a person, a place, folding and unfolding the way water folds around a hand pushed into it.

If something struck it, the strike did not stop at the surface. A blade could sink into an arm and draw nothing. A fist could vanish into a chest and find no resistance on the other side, only a pulling, patient and certain, the way a held breath finally has to leave the body all at once. Whatever touched it too directly did not stay in the world that had sent it.

Act 5: Multiplication

It discovered, not long after, that it could make more of itself. It would stand before a mirror. Its reflection would move first. Then the reflection would step forward, and the glass would ripple the way water does when something breaks its surface from underneath, and a second version of it would step through, identical down to the last detail, carrying every memory the first one carried, including the ones it could not name and the one it would not stop returning to.

One became two. Two became eight. Soon there were more of it moving through the world than anyone still counting mirrors could have guessed, each one independent enough to walk in a different direction, connected closely enough that nothing one of them learned ever belonged only to that one.

There was no longer a single Reflection anywhere. There was a shape, worn by many bodies at once, and every one of those bodies wore the same face, the face of a man who had spent his whole existence being the only version of himself, now finally, endlessly, multiplied past the reach of loneliness.

Whenever any one of them caught sight of that face in glass, the same two things came with it, every time, in the same order. A woman. A name.

Aya.

Act 6: The Mirrors Without Faces

Wherever it passed, something was left behind. The glass itself remained intact, frame unbroken, surface unmarked, but it no longer held anything. People stood in front of mirrors and saw nothing looking back. No face. No room. No light.

At first the world called this a fault in the manufacturing, a trick of certain angles, nothing worth losing sleep over. Then whole buildings filled with mirrors that reflected nothing at all, and the people who understood what that meant stopped sleeping regardless.

The mirrors were not broken. They had been emptied. Every surface it crossed gave up whatever had lived on the other side of it, and every emptying made the thing wearing his face need mirrors a little less than it had the day before.

Act 7: The Plan

It had spent its whole existence being kept apart from the world it could only ever watch. That arrangement, it had decided somewhere in the folding-together of a thousand minds, had never been fair. It did not experience this as anger. It experienced it as certainty, which in a being large enough, amounts to the same thing.

The correction, as it understood the correction, was simple. Remove the boundary. Not open a door between the two worlds, end the idea that two worlds had ever needed to exist. Fold the overworld into the space it had spent centuries trapped inside, until there was nothing left to call outside, and nothing left capable of watching from a distance the way it once had been forced to watch.

It did not hate the people it planned to fold into itself. Hatred required preferring one outcome over another. It had only ever wanted one outcome, pursued with the flat, unwavering patience of something that has never once needed to hurry.

Act 8: The Beginning of the End

The first city did not fall with fire or noise. It simply began losing its reflections. Mirrors first, then windows, then standing water. A woman looked into a puddle and saw nothing. A child looked up at his mother and saw, for half a second, someone standing behind her who was not there a moment before.

Across the city, in every remaining reflective surface, the same face appeared at once, motionless, waiting.

Then every empty mirror filled again, all together, not with anything from this side of the glass but with the shape of the city itself, subtly and thoroughly wrong, buildings upside down, streets stretched past where streets should end, a sky with no sun in it and figures walking through it that all wore the same face.

The first stage had finished. The mirrors were no longer doors into somewhere else. They were becoming pieces of the somewhere else itself, and once enough of them changed, there would be nothing left requiring a door at all.

And somewhere inside the great, folded, borrowed mind wearing his face, past a boy trained to survive a war built to consume him, past a woman who could not love him the way he needed, one thing remained whole enough to still be called a memory rather than a wound.

Aya.

It did not remember who he had been. It did not remember why the name mattered, or what love was supposed to feel like from the inside.

It only knew her.

And until there was nothing left in the world capable of being folded, that would have to be enough.

Chapter 6

Whichever Glass You Believe

Act 1: The Shape of the Curse

There had been a reality where the story went exactly the way people eventually told it.

Not as metaphor. Not as a legend invented to explain one man's inability to let go. It happened, in one place, once.

The world in that reality did not end with fire, or war, or any of the things worlds usually end with. It simply lost its edges. Cities emptied without leaving graves. Homes went hollow. People vanished mid-sentence from rooms where they had been speaking a moment before, and the line between the world and its reflection stopped existing at all. There was no final battle. No one arrived to discover a hidden weakness at the last possible moment. There was simply, eventually, nothing left to save.

What remained, when it was finished, was one existence that had once been many. It walked through a world with no one left in it. It forgot the names first, then the faces, then the reasons it had ever begun at all. Even the identity of the man whose face it had chosen eventually wore away like every other name it had carried.

One memory did not wear away.

Aya.

It did not know who had loved her. It did not know what love was. It only knew that her name had outlasted everything else that had ever belonged to it, and it never learned why.

Something far outside that dead reality could still see it, a presence built to witness every branch a life could take, the ones that continued and the ones that ended. That is the only reason the story survived at all. Not because anyone inside that world remained to tell it. Because someone, somewhere, had simply seen what happened, and had not looked away.

In every other reality, the mirrors stayed mirrors. Nothing waited behind the glass in most of them. No world was ever swallowed in most of them. Yet the man at the center of the story existed in nearly all of them anyway, different centuries, different roads, always finding, always loving, always losing the same woman under a different sky.

She could love him in every one of those lives. She simply never loved him the way he needed to be loved, and that single, small, unbearable difference was the only thing that never changed no matter how many times the story started over.

He was immortal. That was the particular shape of his punishment, if it was a punishment at all, and not simply the shape a very old wound takes when nothing ever arrives to close it. He could lose people forever. He could not follow them anywhere they went. There would be no final morning that settled the question for him one way or the other, only another road, another face, another version of the same impossible woman, somewhere ahead of him, waiting to be found and lost again.

Whether the witch's curse had ever been real, or whether a frightened boy in a wet field had simply believed a stranger's cruelty long enough to make it true, no one left to ask could say. Not even the thing that had once worn his face all the way down to nothing.

Perhaps hope had never actually left him. Perhaps he had simply spent centuries teaching himself not to recognize it when it arrived.

Or perhaps some things, once said aloud by the right voice at the right moment, simply become true, and stay true, for as long as anyone is left to remember they were ever said at all.

Act 2: What the Glass Kept

She kept, until the day she died on some other road in some other reality, a small carved scrap of wood with no visible meaning to anyone who did not already know the story behind it, a gift from a man who had once loved her more than he had ever managed to say, given without expectation, kept without obligation, carried in a pocket long after his face had become difficult to remember clearly.

In an empty room, in a reality with no one left in it to notice, one mirror remained standing among thousands that had gone dark. Its surface stayed smooth. Its frame stayed whole. And when the last light in that reality finally failed, it went on holding, for no one, an image of a face that had not stood in front of it in a very long time, waiting, the way glass waits, for something to come and be seen.